

Skill & Product Library / RevOps

Platform

Shipped

Clay Credit Governance

Cutting enrichment cost ~70% by making overspend structurally impossible.

~70% cost reduction by design — Lean 15 / Balanced 21 / Full 50 credits per row

Clay

FinOps

cost control

enrichment

HubSpot



Overview

A credit-governance framework for Clay — the GTM enrichment platform where every lookup costs credits. After a runaway spend incident at a global HR-tech (EOR) platform (background workflows burned a large credit purchase in roughly a month, at ~50 credits/row), the enrichment layer was audited end to end and rebuilt around one standard, cloneable table: a free ICP gate before any paid column, tiered build profiles (Lean ~15 / Balanced ~21 / Full ~50 credits/row), one capped phone column, skip-logic everywhere, and a per-row cost estimate. Paired with recurring spend reports to the budget-owning leader and an hourly AI-credit watcher, no AI spend runs unmonitored again.

The Problem

In a recent quarter, Clay workflows running in the background at a global HR-tech (EOR) platform consumed a large credit purchase in about a month — with no monitoring, no pre-run cost visibility, and builds averaging ~50 credits/row (stacked phone providers re-buying the same number, multiple contacts per company, AI columns firing on every row). The overspend was owned directly, then turned into the system that makes it structurally impossible.

How It Works

1. **Clone the standard table** (a reusable Clay workspace template — Clay is a spreadsheet-style enrichment tool where each column calls a data provider). Inputs: company name, domain, LinkedIn URL, account tier.
2. **Free columns run first.** Columns execute left-to-right, cheap-to-expensive. Firmographics (0.5 credits) skip rows where employee count is already known.
3. **A free ICP-gate formula scores every row** (employee band, target geographies). Rows scoring below threshold never trigger a paid column — the org never pays to enrich a non-ICP row.
4. **One decision-maker per company** via people-search (1 credit), replacing the old multiple-contacts-per-company pattern.
5. **One mobile-phone column, capped at 3 provider attempts**, with runConditions (Clay's skip-logic) so a populated phone is never re-bought; company phone and additional phone are separate, deduped columns.
6. **Expensive AI columns (Claygent hooks, international-hiring research, HTTP intent news) are gated to top-tier accounts only** — Claygent is Clay's built-in AI research agent.
7. **A free `est_credit_cost` column sums what actually ran**, and the governance loop closes with recurring spend reports to leadership plus an hourly AI-credit watcher with 4-tier alert thresholds and month-end forecasting.



Stack & Integrations

Tool	Role	Access needed
Clay	Enrichment tables, formulas, waterfalls, runConditions, Claygent	Workspace admin
Clay credit/usage export	Spend audit + recurring reporting dataset	Workspace usage visibility
CRM (HubSpot)	AI-credit watcher (hourly, 4-tier alerts, month-end forecast)	Usage/reporting read access
Spreadsheet / Markdown reports	Leadership-facing spend packages	Local files only

Setup Process

1. Clone the standard enrichment table (schema JSON + design doc provided) into your Clay workspace.
2. Edit the ICP-gate formula to your ICP: employee band + target-country list.

3. Set each list's tier column and pick a build profile (Lean / Balanced / Full) against the remaining credit balance — the design doc includes an allocation rule of thumb.
4. Verify runConditions reference your actual CRM field names (existing phone, email).
5. Dry-run 25–50 rows and sanity-check `est_credit_cost` before a full run.
6. Stand up the recurring spend report and credit-watcher thresholds; ban live work from "Copy of" tables (use campaign-named canonical tables).

What You Need

- [] Clay workspace with admin access and credit-usage export
- [] A written ICP definition (employee band, geographies) and account-tier assignments
- [] Optional: CRM access for the AI-credit watcher
- [] Roughly half a day to clone, adapt, and dry-run



Results

- Predictable spend profiles: **Lean ~15 • Balanced ~21 • Full ~50 credits/row** vs. an audited average of ~50 across all builds — up to ~70% cost reduction by design.
- Free ICP gate: zero paid enrichment on non-ICP rows.
- Post-review audit: over 90% of a full-month credit spend traced to deliberate, requested project runs — runaway spend eliminated; the remaining governance gap ("Copy of" tables, roughly a fifth of spend) converted into an enforced rule.
- Recurring leadership-level spend reporting + hourly AI-credit watcher: no company AI spend runs unmonitored.

Challenges & Fixes

- **Same phone number bought 2–3 times** → stacked phone waterfalls re-purchasing what people-search already returned → three distinct phone columns with dedupe runConditions; mobile capped at 3 provider attempts.
- **AI columns firing on every row** → no gating → Claygent/HTTP columns restricted to top-tier accounts by runCondition.
- **Nobody saw spend until credits were gone** → no pre-run visibility → free `est_credit_cost` column, recurring leadership report, hourly credit watcher with forecasting.
- **"Copy of" tables kept burning credits** → cloned tables left live → canonical campaign-named tables + row cap on unapproved manual runs.

Demonstrates

FinOps thinking applied to AI/data tooling · turning an owned failure into an enforced standard · cost control by architecture, not vigilance · leadership-facing reporting.

STACK & INTEGRATIONS

Clay

HubSpot

WHAT IT NEEDS

- ✓ Clay workspace with admin access and credit-usage export
- ✓ A written ICP definition (employee band, geographies) and account tiers
- ✓ Optional: CRM access for the AI-credit watcher



DISCUSS THIS BUILD

Happy to walk through the architecture, the failures along the way, or how this could translate to your team.

Email Patrick

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